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weight of an object is denoted as, W=N=mg. Note that even though magnitude of weight is equal to mg, it is not same as gravitational force acting on the object.

Apparent weight in elevators

Everyone who used an elevator would have felt a jerk when the elevator takes off or stops. Why does it happen? Understanding the concept of weight is crucial for explaining this effect. Let us consider a man inside an elevator in the following scenarios.

When a man is standing in the elevator, there are two forces acting on him.

1. Gravitational force which acts downward. If we take the vertical direction as positive y direction, the gravitational force acting on the man is $\vec{F}_G = -mg\hat{j}$
2. The normal force exerted by floor on the man which acts vertically upward, $\vec{N} = N\hat{j}$

Case (i) When the elevator is at rest

The acceleration of the man is zero. Therefore the net force acting on the man is zero. With respect to inertial frame (ground), applying Newton's second law on the man,

$$\vec{F}_G + \vec{N} = 0$$
$$-mg\hat{j} + N\hat{j} = 0$$

By comparing the components, we can write

$$N - mg = 0 \text{ (or) } N = mg \qquad (6.67)$$

Since weight, W =N, the apparent weight of the man is equal to his actual weight.

Case (ii) When the elevator is moving uniformly in the upward or downward direction

In uniform motion (constant velocity), the net force acting on the man is still zero. Hence, in this case also the apparent weight of the man is equal to his actual weight. It is shown in Figure 6.23(a)

Case (iii) When the elevator is accelerating upwards

If an elevator is moving with upward acceleration ($\vec{a} = a\hat{j}$) with respect to inertial frame (ground), applying Newton's second law on the man,

$$\vec{F}_G + \vec{N} = m\vec{a}$$

Writing the above equation in terms of unit vector in the vertical direction,

$$-mg\hat{j} + N\hat{j} = ma\hat{j}$$

By comparing the components,

$$N = m\,(g + a) \qquad (6.68)$$

Therefore, apparent weight of the man is greater than his actual weight. It is shown in Figure 6.23(b)

Case (iv) When the elevator is accelerating downwards

If the elevator is moving with downward acceleration ($\vec{a} = -a\hat{j}$), by applying Newton's second law on the man, we can write

$$\vec{F}_G + \vec{N} = m\vec{a}$$

Writing the above equation in terms of unit vector in the vertical direction,

$$-mg\hat{j} + N\hat{j} = -ma\hat{j}$$

By comparing the components,

$$N = m\,(g - a) \qquad (6.69)$$